

The difference in numbers between 1963 and 1971 in the status groups of own account workers and unpaid family workers is due mainly to a large number of those engaged in agricultural occupations being omitted from these categories in 1963. Between 1953 and 1963 there have been large decreases in other occupation groups too. It could still, however, be inferred that the activity rate is to some degree affected by the timing of the census, the use of the gainful occupation concept notwithstanding, and that a number of women are willing to work and would do so if work is available which could be performed in or near their homes. This may also be part of the explanation for the big increase in unemployed women recorded at the 1971 Census when the definitions of the "unemployed" was expanded to include all those who were available for work even if not actively seeking it.

Old Persons - Those aged 60 years and over form about a sixteenth of the population. This proportion has been increasing slowly over the years while the proportion of the labour force in this age group has been declining. The activity rate has declined steadily and considerably over the 25 year period. This declining trend in the older age groups is a feature characteristic of countries in the process of development, and could be expected to continue, as more and more establishments lower the age of compulsory retirement.

Table 9.10 gives the percentage distribution of persons aged 60 years and over by activity status. Among the economically inactive in this age group, the males are mostly classified either as too old to work or as income recipients and pensioners, while among the females a large number are engaged in home duties. A noticeable difference between the sexes is that the proportion of those recorded as too old to work is much higher among women than among men.

TABLE 9.10 : PERCENTAGE DISTRIBUTION BY ACTIVITY STATUS OF OLD PERSONS AGED 60 YEARS AND OVER, 1971

	Employed	Unemployed	Engaged in Home Duties	Income Recipient and Pensioners	Too old or Unable to Work	Others	Total
Total	28.75	2.34	15.50	8.26	43.95	1.17	100
Male	48.12	2.48	1.85	11.07	35.10	1.35	100
Female	5.16	2.18	32.11	4.84	54.73	0.96	100

9.5 Industrial Classification

The distribution of the employed population as recorded at the 1953, 1963 and 1971 Censuses according to the major divisions of the Standard Industrial Classification of all Economic Activities is shown in Table B in the Appendix. The Industrial Classification used for the 1971 Census of population was based on the 1968 Revision of the International Standard Industrial Classification of all economic activities. Hence, data for the earlier years have been rearranged to conform to the classifications adopted in 1971. Major division of Agriculture, Hunting, Forestry and Fishing has been further subdivided to highlight employment in tea, rubber and coconut cultivation and in fishing. In Sri Lanka, the cultivation of tea, rubber and coconut is very well organised and most of those employed on these plantations are paid workers as opposed to the large number of own account workers and unpaid family workers engaged in other traditional agricultural pursuits.